

Automating Certificate Generation for Events Using GIMP



This article should interest DIY enthusiasts, providing them with the knowhow to generate multiple customised certificates using GIMP. With a little bit of Python and GIMP, one can add value to events by issuing computer generated certificates to participants – all in quick time and without much effort.

Let's assume that your organisation is conducting a mega event and is expecting participants in the hundreds. Since no one is supposed to go back empty handed, all the participants are assured a participation certificate. As luck would have it, the work of generating those certificates falls upon you. What would you do?

Like those in many large (and smart) organisations, you too can automate the task of generating certificates. A quick search for certificate generators shows up a number of online tools or Windows-specific tools. On the GNU/Linux side we have the trusty LaTeX for certificate generation. But LaTeX is mainly for typesetting. So the GIMP can be given a try, and why not? It's free, and it's open source, with a great community backing it.

Okay, So where do I start?

The prerequisites for doing this are that you must have GIMP and Python 2.7 installed on your system - you could use Python 3 but you might need to modify the code a little. It helps if you have a little knowledge of Python and GIMP. Even if you do not, you could just follow the steps here to get what you need - hundreds of customised certificates!

Here's how we do it

- 1) Create or download a certificate template (the background image for your certificate). Open your certificate template using GIMP (right-click on the file and open with GNU Image Manipulation Program), or you could alternatively open GIMP and open your file from there using *File -> Open*. For this demo, we are using a template with a red background and some text.
- 2) Now type some dummy text where you expect the name of the participant, contest, etc. to appear. To keep it simple, let us have only one text `<name>`. To do this, click on the **A** button in the GIMP toolbox (it is usually on the left side), and then click and drag your mouse over the image so that a rectangular box appears right above the line. You can type the text here - placement is crucial because the participants' names will be substituted in this location. You can change the font size in the menu above the box and drag the box at its sides, for proper alignment.
- 3) If you look at the layer toolbox (it is normally on the right side, and if not, it can be opened using *Windows -> Dockable Dialogs -> Layers*) you should now see two